The Perfect Way;

OR,

The Finding of Christ.

DEC 1882
BODLEIANA

LONDON:
FIELD & TUER, YE LEADENHALLE PRESSE, E.C.
HAMILTON, ADAMS & CO., PATERNOSTER ROW, E.C.
NEW YORK: SCRIBNER & WELFORD, 743 & 745, BROADWAY.

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1882.

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PART IV.

31. In every part of the world of antiquity exist memorials of the Sacred Mysteries and tokens of the ceremonials which accompanied initiation into them. The scene of these ceremonials was generally a subterranean labyrinth, natural or artificial, the object being to symbolise the several acts in the Drama of Regeneration as occurring in the interior and secret recesses of man's being. The Catacombs of Rome, used for similar purposes by the early Christians, were suggestive of the same idea, though this was not the immediate motive for the selection of such a retreat to be the home of the infant Church. And explorers of the passages under the Great Temple of Edfou relate how, after traversing with extreme difficulty a tunnel thirty inches high and forty-two inches wide, they emerge into a large hall adorned with a profusion of sacred paintings and hieroglyphs. Similar excavations have been found at Hermione in Greece, Nauplia, Gadara, Ptelion, Phyle, and other places. And all accounts agree in stating that the Mysteries were variously celebrated in pyramids, pagodas, and labyrinths which were furnished with vaulted rooms, extensive wings, open and spacious galleries, and numerous secret caverns, passages, and vistas, terminating in mysterious *adyta*. And in describing a catacomb in Upper Egypt, called *Biban el Moluk*, Belzoni mentions an alabaster chest deposited therein, which, though surmised by him to have been intended as a sarcophagus, resembled rather the coffers used in the religious celebrations for which such labyrinths were designed. Similar constructions, of vast antiquity, abound in Upper Egypt, and bear, in their hieroglyphical remains,

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indications of having been meant for similar purposes. The story of the Labyrinth at Crete, and the Minotaur who, until finally subdued by Theseus, devoured those who entered therein, is a parable of the Mysteries and the dangerous nature of the ordeals to be encountered by candidates for initiation.

32. But of all existing memorials of these institutions, the most wonderful is that known as the Great Pyramid of Gizeh, the formative idea and purpose of which has for ages baffled inquirers. This artificial mountain of stone is, however, no other than a religious symbol setting forth in its every detail from base to apex the method of that which constitutes the title and subject of these lectures, namely, the *Perfect Way*, and *The Finding of Christ*. Outwardly, its form denotes the ascent of the soul, as a flame ever aspiring, from the material plane to union with the Divine, and attaining this union through Christ, who, as "the Headstone of the corner," is symbolised by the topmost point of the pyramid—that wherein, as the culmination, completion, and perfection of the whole creation, the earthly is "taken up" into the heavenly, or existence into pure Being. The successive layers of stone form a series of steps from the base to the summit, and represent the various stages of the soul's upward progress in its ascent of the "hill of the Lord;"—an idea expressed by Peter when he wrote,—"Be ye also as living stones built up a spiritual house, acceptable to God by Christ Jesus. As it is said, Behold I lay in Sion a chief corner-stone, elect and precious." Similarly, Paul says,—"Christ Jesus himself is the chief corner stone, in whom all the building, being fitly framed together, groweth up into an holy temple in the Lord. In whom ye also are built together, into an habitation of God in the

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Spirit." Thus is the whole intention of Creation, from its lowest to its highest plane, recognised as finding its fulfilment and realisation in the headstone which is at once the *Christos* and the *Chrestos*, the "Anointed" and the "Best," being Anointed because the Best, and the Best because the Anointed. In being, moreover, four-sided, like the Heavenly city of the Apocalypse, and culminating in respect of each side in an angle, the Pyramid denotes the fourfold nature at once of the Macrocosm and the Microcosm and the final assumption of each kingdom of Nature, through Evolution, into the At-one-ment of Christ.[1]

33. Interiorly, the Pyramid is designed to illustrate, both in character and in duration, the various stages of the soul's history, from her first immergence in Matter to her final triumphant release and return to Spirit. In this view was constructed the complicated system of shafts, passages, and chambers recently described and drawn, after researches involving extraordinary toil, skill, and care, by Professor Piazzi Smyth. Of the two shafts, one, whereby the light from without enters the edifice, points directly to the Pole-star at its lower culmination 2,500 B.C., the date given as that of the erection of the Pyramid. By this is indicated the idea of the soul as a ray proceeding from God as the Pole-star and source of all things, whose Seven

[1] The statement of Manetho and Herodotus, that this pyramid was built by the Egyptians under compulsion of a foreign and hated people who obtained temporary dominion over them, may be regarded as due to a literal acceptation of some mystical legend intended to imply that it was built by Egypt's body or State at the dictation of Egypt's soul or Church, by the physical element, that is, of the country, in obedience to the spiritual element, and as a monument in illustration of the power of the soul over the body, and of Spirit working in Matter.

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Spirits,—like the seven stars of the constellation called by us the *Great Bear*, but by the Mystics of old, more significantly, *the Sheepfold*—keep watch and ward over the universe, yet ever indicate the Supreme. Of this shaft the opposite extremity terminates in a pit lying below the centre of the Pyramid. Constituting the only portion of the whole structure which is unpaved, this pit represents the bottomless abyss of negation, and, consequently, final destruction. Descending thither, the ray would become extinguished; and such is the fate of the soul which, entering into Matter, persists in a downward course. The pyramid, however, is designed expressly to represent the way of salvation; and it accordingly provides a passage turning out of that just described, and leading upwards towards the centre of the edifice, just beyond which centre lies the principal apartment, which is called the "King's Chamber." This is reached by a series of passages, steep, narrow, intricate, and in some parts so contracted in dimensions as to compel the explorer to traverse them on his hands and knees. Such peculiarities of construction, involving an exercise of great ingenuity, skill, and labour, could not, it is obvious, have been introduced into a structure intended, as some have suggested, as a granary or as a tomb. The "King's Chamber," which terminates the series, is a large vaulted apartment having six roofs or ceilings, composed in all of seven stones, placed one above another, the two topmost stones forming an angle. In the centre of this chamber is a coffer, hollowed out of a single stone, and representing in its proportions and dimensions the idea thus expressed in the Epistle to the Ephesians :— "When we all meet in the unity of faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto *the*

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measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ." In a coffer such as this, the candidate who had successfully encountered all the ordeals symbolised in the passages of the pyramid, was, at his final initiation, laid as a corpse in a sarcophagus. And the Initiator, who presided on the occasion, was a woman—a priestess—who was called the "Mother," and who acted as the sponsor representative of Isis, the universal soul and intuition of Humanity. By this funeral ceremony was denoted the death of the candidate to things merely material and sensible, and his attainment of the grade of a Man Regenerate. It has its continuance and correspondence in the rite whereby, in the Catholic Church, candidates for reception into the "religious" life make final profession of the vows which sever them from the world. This burial concluded, as still in the Catholic Church, by the "rising from the dead" of the candidate, who, having quitted the tomb, was invested with the insignia of his new condition, and received the "new" or "religious" name, bestowed by the Sponsor. This name in the Egyptian and allied Mysteries, was *Issa*, or *Iesous*, that is, son of Isis, and therein child of the Soul, and "Seed of the Woman." Thus was symbolised the gift of eternal life through Christ, the second or new birth of the Man Regenerate, attained only by gradual and painful processes of ascent, extending over many lives, and requiring for their accomplishment desire so fervent, perseverance so great, and courage so indomitable, as not only to deter many of the candidates at the outset, but to turn back some even when far advanced. It is manifestly from the details of this ceremonial, with which, as an "Initiate," the Jesus of the Gospels was familiar, that was derived his allusion to the "Second Birth," and the idea expressed in the warning: "Strait is the

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gate and narrow is the way that leadeth unto Life, and few there be that find it."

34. Such was the mode whereby was accomplished initiation into those greater Mysteries of which the culminating stage was termed the *Ascension.* The lesser Mysteries, the "acts" of which were designated the Baptism or Betrothal, the Temptation or Trial, and the Passion, are symbolised in the great pyramid by the apartment called the Queen's Chamber. This is situated considerably below the King's Chamber and in the northern section of the building; and is reached by a level passage, at the commencement of which is a precipitous chasm, having for bottom the pit already described, and betokening the fate of those who fail to become regenerate, and consequently the danger escaped by those who have attained initiation into things spiritual. The Queen's Chamber serves also as the "Banqueting Hall," wherein, after his accomplishment of the three acts named, the candidate celebrates the "Solemnisation." He is then qualified to proceed to the greater Mysteries of which the final scene is the "King's Chamber." This, as already said, is placed at the extreme summit of the passages, and beyond the centre of the Pyramid; and its purpose is to symbolise that kingdom of heaven which the Initiate attains by what is called the Divine Marriage, an act which separates him altogether from his life of the past. The six superposed beams which compose the ceiling of this chamber denote the "six crowns" of the Man Regenerate, that is, the six acts or stages of initiation, of which three appertain to the lesser and three to the greater Mysteries. These "crowns," therefore, are Baptism, Temptation, Passion, Burial, Resurrection, and Ascension. Of all these the

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ultimate object is that full and complete Redemption which, by its realisation of the soul's supreme felicity, is termed the "Marriage of the Son of God." And in the second shaft passing upwards through the pyramid, from the topmost point of the last gallery, and pointing in one direction to the coffer in the King's Chamber, and in the other direction to the pole-star at its greatest altitude, may be seen symbolised the return to God of the soul, perfected and triumphant, on her final release from Matter. So that by the two pole-star-pointing shafts are typified respectively the forces centrifugal and centripetal, the Will and the Love, from the operation of which proceed Creation and Redemption. (Fig. 8.)

35. Between the "Resurrection" and "Ascension" of the Man Regenerate, is an interval which—in accordance with the mystical system of making all dates which relate to the soul's history coincide with the corresponding solar periods—is termed "Forty Days." The actual length of the period, however, is dependent upon individual circumstance. The New Testament contains nothing incompatible with the suggestion that Jesus may have lived on the earth for many years after his "Resurrection," and was therefore still in the body when seen of Paul. For that which occurs at the expiration of this cycle is not a quittance of the earth in the physical sense ordinarily supposed, but the complete withdrawal of the man into his own interior and celestial region. The Spirit attains the Sabbath of perfection only by attaining Rest or Quiescence; and to this Sabbath—or Nirvana—the Man Regenerate necessarily attains, sooner or later, after his "Crucifixion" and "Resurrection"; and the attainment of it constitutes his "Ascension." There are then no longer two wills. The

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Fig. 8.

A. Upper culmination of Pole-star of 2500 B.C.

B. Lower culmination of Pole-star of 2500 B.C.

C. Grand Gallery (1881 inches long).

D. Narrow Ascending Passage (1540 inches long).

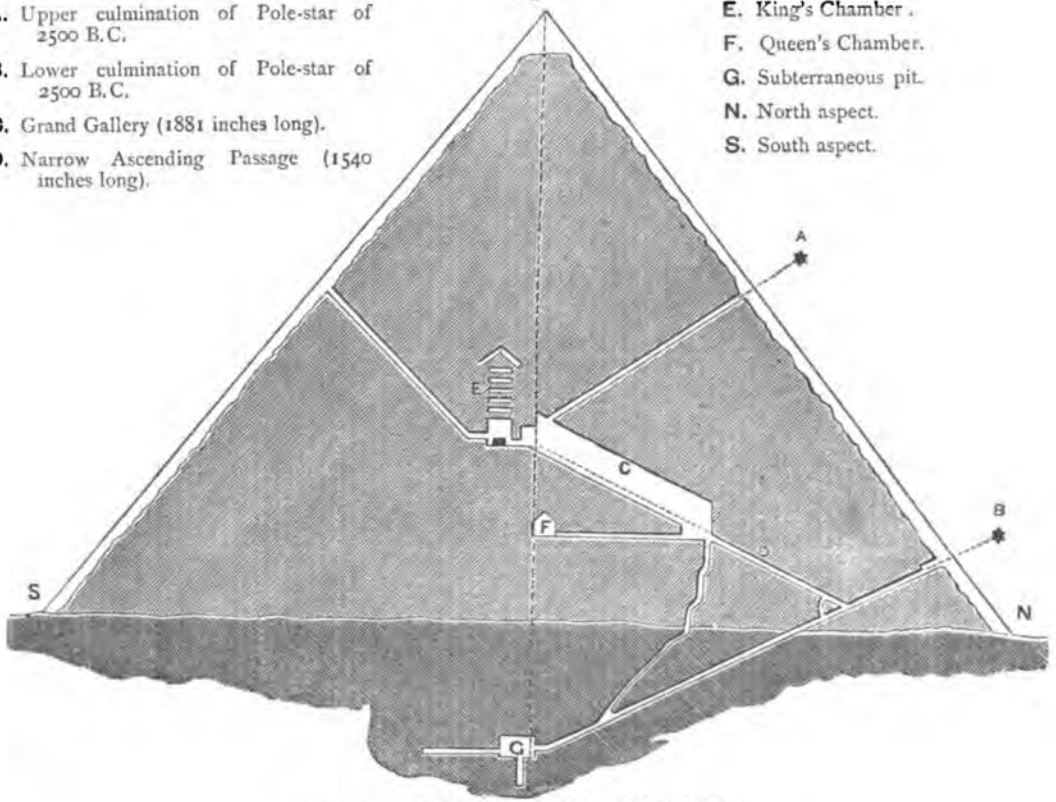
E. King's Chamber.

F. Queen's Chamber.

G. Subterraneous pit.

N. North aspect.

S. South aspect.



Section of the Great Pyramid of Gizeh.

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